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REVISITING THE CULT OF “ŚIVA-BUDDHA” IN JAVA AND BALI

Andrea Acri

INTRODUCTION

As testified to by the extant written sources and archaeological remains, Śivaism was the dominant religion in Java and Bali. However, Śivaism coexisted alongside Buddhism for more than a millennium, from *circa* the fifth century CE through the late fifteenth century in Java, and on Bali until today.¹ The coexistence of the two religions eventually gave rise to phenomena of confrontation, dialectic and integration that have attracted scholarly attention since the late nineteenth century. The most influential studies have sanctioned the view that the variety of “Hinduism” widespread in Java and Bali was fundamentally syncretic in character, forming a blend of Śaiva and Bauddha elements. What has been generally termed the “religion of Śiva-Buddha” or “Hindu-Buddhist religion” (in Indonesian *Agama Siwa-Buda* or *Agama Hindu-Buda*), and ascribed to the Hindu-Buddhist era (*jaman Hindu-Buda*) of Javanese history, has been characterized mostly in terms of “identity”, “syncretism”, “parallelism” or “coalition”. Whether the emphasis be laid on equality, integration or symbiosis between the two systems, their respective deities or their paramount goals, the dynamics shaping the resulting “cult of Śiva-Buddha” have often been regarded as having been subjected to distinctive local

features that set this tradition apart from the more rigidly sectarian South Asian traditions from which it originated.²

Even though our understanding of (Tantric) Śivaism and (Tantric) Buddhism in the Indian Subcontinent and Tibet has improved dramatically over the last two decades, the majority of the most recent studies touching upon these religious traditions in Indonesia appear to be insufficiently aware of these developments. It seems thus worthwhile to discuss once again the relationship between Śivaism and Buddhism in the Subcontinent and in the Archipelago from a comparative perspective, in the hope that this approach will stimulate a cross-fertilization between the disciplines of Indology and Indonesian studies.

The basic idea that my paper tries to convey is that the nature of the equation of the paramount principles of Śivaism and Buddhism as expressed by a number of Old Javanese sources from the Singhasari-Majapahit period has not always been correctly grasped, and that alleged instances of “Javanese syncretism” should now be challenged.

SURVEYING THE APPROACHES TO THE JAVANO-BALINESE “ŚIVA-BUDDHA RELIGION”

The ‘identity’ paradigm was at first formulated by Kern.³ On account of his reading of the Old Javanese Kakawin *Sutasoma* by Mpu Tantular (c. fourteenth century CE), he suggested that in ancient Java there occurred a mixture or blending (*vermenging*) of Śiva and Buddha. As he based himself mostly on the comparison with Nepalese and Indian sources, he did not consider the Javanese local culture to have been an important factor in shaping this situation. This view was supported by Krom⁴ on the basis of iconographical evidence, but adjusted by Rassers⁵ who, although still endorsing the term “blending”, explained it in terms of local background and ancestral myths of the Malayo-Polynesian tribe, especially as reflected by the popular Balinese tale of Bubhukṣa and Gagan Akin.⁶ Both Krom⁷ and Rassers⁸ alongside the term “blending” also used “syncretism”. Use of the term syncretism was endorsed by Zoetmulder,⁹ but was opposed by Pigeaud,¹⁰ who defined the relationship of Śivaism and Buddhism in Majapahit Java as “parallelism”. According to him, that dichotomous religious structure developed as a result of the classificatory attitude and dualistic pattern of thought that were common features of the ancient Javanese culture.

Unsatisfied with the previous perspectives, Gonda¹¹ employed the term “coalition”, which from the point of view of theology implies a search for the same ultimate goal using different and distinct methods. To corroborate

his theory, Gonda¹² pointed at the occurrence of similar phenomena in Nepal and Cambodia, and showed that many Old Javanese sources equated not only Śīva with Buddha but also with the highest manifestation of truth belonging to several other schools as well. Gonda’s view was endorsed by Soebadio,¹³ according to whom this coalition involved no mixing of systems, but rather presupposed different ways to achieve the ultimate truth, just as two different paths lead towards the summit of a mountain. This idea was adopted also by Supomo,¹⁴ de Casparis¹⁵ and Santoso.¹⁶

A view somewhat closer to Pigeaud’s “parallelism” was elaborated by Ensink,¹⁷ who analysed Śīvaism and Buddhism in Majapahit Java as a dual system based on the concept of bipolarity that is found in Javanese wayang puppetry as well as in the Indian tradition. Ensink also took account of the more recent Balinese tradition — and especially the aforementioned tale of Bubhuṣa and Gagaṇ Akiṇ first analysed by Rassers — to show how the local people perceived the two religions: Śīvaism was regarded to be the older system, while Buddhism the younger, yet the most perfect (or effective) one.

More than a decade later, Nihom¹⁸ challenged the assumption that the Śīva-Buddha coalition of Majapahit Java was a local distinguishing characteristic and — to an even greater extent than Kern and Gonda — emphasized data from the Indian Subcontinent. He argued that the admixture of Śaiva and Bauddha elements found in East Java has to be seen as a common feature of a significant part of Tantric Bauddha literature from the Subcontinent as well as Tibet, where it is virtually impossible to distinguish the Bauddha and Śaiva elements as separated and opposed.

In a recent groundbreaking article, Hunter¹⁹ has challenged the idea that the Lord Śīva-Buddha (*bhaṭāra śīvabuddha*) often mentioned in Majapahit sources was part of an established syncretic religious system, arguing that such a situation was due to the politico-religious hegemony introduced by the ruler Kṛtanagara (r. 1265–92 CE), who was deified as a form of both Śīva and Buddha. Hunter has further defined the “syncretism” documented in literary works and artistic remains of the Singhasari period of East Javanese history as a “series of initiatives undertaken by Kṛtanagara with the ultimate aim of forcing a fusion of elements that represented the metaphysical reflection of his pragmatic political policies”.²⁰

RECENT APPROACHES TO ŚAIVA-BAUDDHA DIALECTICS IN THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT

Considerable advancements in the understanding of Śīvaism and Buddhism and their mutual relationship in the medieval Indian Subcontinent and

Tibet have been achieved in the last two decades or so, mostly thanks to the editing, translating and studying of various scriptures belonging to the vast corpus of nearly coeval Sanskrit and Tibetan textual materials related to the category of Tantra.²¹ What are now called Tantric Śaivism and Tantric Buddhism by scholars have turned out to share significant common elements, such as an interdependence of discourse in such disparate domains as philosophy, soteric practices, ritual and iconography. This complex phenomenon of mutual dialectic influence, interchange and interdependence has triggered a wide range of etic interpretations, but three main hermeneutical models have come to dominate the scholarly debate.

The first position, called “substratum model” by its main advocate David Seyfort Ruegg,²² posits an early “pan-Indian religious substratum” or common cultic stock — mainly constituted by “folk” religion — that would *ex hypothesi* form the common source from which both Śaiva and Bauddha traditions derived, and to which they ultimately owe their shared common elements. Seyfort Ruegg questions that the two religions make sense as discrete and opposed entities “requiring to be kept neatly apart at all levels of analysis”.²³ He further detects in the original textual sources the existence of the emic opposition between the categories of *lokottara* and *laukika*, respectively “supra-mundane” and “mundane”. This contrastive structure distinguishes two superordinate dimensions within any manifestation of belief, ritual or conduct, where the lower one (*laukika*) is opposed in the sense of relative, inferior and subordinate to the higher one (*lokottara*), or ultimate.²⁴

The “substratum model” has been criticized by Alexis Sanderson,²⁵ mainly on account of its being an abstract and unverifiable, i.e. inferred but never perceived, concept or entity. Sanderson himself has elaborated a paradigm that has been later labelled by his readers, and in particular by his main criticizer Seyfort Ruegg, “borrowing model”. Sanderson’s research on Sanskrit primary sources of the Śaiva Mantramārga and the Bauddha Yogatantra has highlighted the divide existing between the two traditions, and justified the common elements on the grounds of a great deal of mutual influences, or even manifest plagiarism, occurring between both systems — especially the incorporation of materials of the former, and arguably earlier, textual corpus into the latter. Sanderson has found strong evidence for incorporation of scriptures of the Śaiva canon into the Bauddha Yogāniruttaratantras, and has defined the origin of the dependence of Bauddha Yoginītantras on Śaiva scriptural sources as a “pious plagiarism” of the latter religion on the former.²⁶ Furthermore,

he has stressed the somewhat syncretic attitude of lay devotionism, characterized by an “inclusivist” attitude that was equally followed in the Subcontinent as in the periphery, e.g., in Java and Cambodia.²⁷ Rather than a simple opposition between *laukika* and *lokottara*, Sanderson distinguishes in Śaiva texts an emic strategy of polemicizing with different religious and philosophical systems by placing them on a hierarchical scale as “lower level” truths.

In addition to the “substratum model” and the “borrowing model”, we can distinguish a third popular paradigm, which Seyfort Ruegg²⁸ has called “agonistic view”, namely “a more or less secular and historicist interpretation of the schema as representing the agonistic or hostile relation ‘Buddhism’ vs. ‘Hinduism’ in the world, i.e. in history”. According to this view, hostility or (ant)agonism between the two religions is reflected in either actual historical events, such as various forms of competition for royal support, devotees and resources, occasional interreligious violence, or iconographic representations, such as Hindu gods being trampled upon or subdued by Buddhist deities, and vice versa.

The textual evidence presented and analysed in a persuasive manner by Sanderson makes the “borrowing model” an entirely plausible and effective hermeneutical tool. Whereas this standpoint seamlessly espouses the “agonistic model” insofar as it assumes the existence of a divide between the borrower and the source tradition, it may also be used alongside the “substratum model”. Notwithstanding his criticism of the model proposed by Sanderson, Seyfort Ruegg himself²⁹ seems to have adopted a somewhat conciliating position when acknowledging that the two models are not necessarily exclusive of each other, for they can be applied to particular cases and, in any event, in order that the borrowing could take place meaningfully one has to suppose a shared ground represented by his postulated “common substratum”. This position is consonant with the attempt by Sferra³⁰ to integrate the two models, pointing out that they both retain validity insofar as Śivaism and Buddhism share a

“common way of interpreting reality and of relating to it, which is expressed in a common soteriological strategy”. This common “substratum of beliefs and soteric practices” is the presupposition that allowed Buddhist authors to include passages or verses from non-dualist Hindu Tantras in their scriptures, and that permitted Hindu redactors to act in a similar way. Seen from such a perspective, this “substratum”, unlike the supposed substratum of the folk religion, is neither radically inaccessible nor hidden.³¹

THE THREE MODELS APPLIED TO ANCIENT JAVANESE ŚIVAISM AND BUDDHISM

The most popular hermeneutical paradigm applied to the study of Śivaism and Buddhism in ancient Java appears to be the “secular-historicist view”, which lays emphasis on political, social and historical realities. With respect to pre tenth-century Central Java, one theory has regarded Śivaism as standing in opposition to Buddhism and assumed that the former succeeded the latter. Advocates of this theory were Coedès,³² Krom³³ and de Casparis,³⁴ who opposed the Bauddha dynasty of the (non-Javanese) Śailendras, which sponsored the building of Borobudur, to the Śaiva Sañjaya “dynasty” of Javanese pedigree. The latter line of kings would have erected the temple complex of Prambanan in order to celebrate the victory of Śivaism over Buddhism and the expulsion of the Śailendras from Java.

Following the criticism expressed earlier by Damais,³⁵ Jordaan³⁶ has challenged this view, arguing that Central Javanese rulers freely patronized both religions, which peacefully co-existed on the island. Pointing at the fact that the Śivagr̥ha inscription of 856 CE describes several important parts of what seems to be the complex of Prambanan, which may have been built before the expulsion of the Śailendras in 855, and furthermore at the stylistic resemblance and physical proximity of Bauddha and Śaiva temples at the complex, he maintains that the two religions closely and harmoniously coexisted.³⁷ Relying upon previous works by Bosch³⁸ and Sarkar,³⁹ Jordaan concluded that emphasis should be laid on the input by India, where “no sharp distinction existed between the followers of various Hindu and Buddhists creeds”, and “existing differences were [...] obliterated even more in the course of the ongoing development of Mahāyāna in a tantristic direction”.⁴⁰ Jordaan and Wessing are further “inclined to question the validity of some current designations [such] as ‘Hinduism’ and ‘Buddhism’ and to wonder whether these terms do full justice to the ideas of the Javanese of the times [...] Both early Hinduism and Buddhism were flexible enough to accommodate and utilize each other’s icons”.⁴¹

This view closely accords with that elaborated by Nihom with respect to East Javanese Tantric Śivaism and Buddhism. Nihom, who relied upon the “substratum model” elaborated by Seyfort Ruegg, maintained that

the academic distinction of “Buddhist” and “Hindu” texts may obscure rather than reveal. Upon reflection, this is not so strange, for the notion that esoteric Buddhism and Hinduism were separate in the sense of being incarnate as “churches” around the middle of the first millennium

in the Subcontinent may indeed prove to be a false superimposition of European religious history not only upon the history of the texts, but more generally in terms of social history.⁴²

In criticizing the view, advanced by Teeuw and Robson,⁴³ that the Kakawin *Kuñjarakarna* was uniquely the product of the syncretistic Śiva-Buddha system of the Majapahit period, Nihom⁴⁴ perceived that text and similar ones as thoroughly Tantric Buddhist products, which could be properly understood only in the light of a South Asian religious substratum mingling Hindu and Bauddha elements. Arguing against “the accepted notion that the admixture of Hindu and Buddhist tantric or tantristic elements is both a peculiar and pervasive characteristic of the religious culture of the islands and mainland of Southeast Asia”, Nihom remarked that

the “syncretism” of “Hindu” and “Buddhist” divinities in these *maṇḍalas* is ultimately of Indian origin. Hence, in future, a perception of the co-existence of “Hindu” and “Buddhist” elements in the Archipelago may not be taken *sui generis* as evidence for Indonesian syncretism.⁴⁵

A position that seems to be middling between the “agonistic model” and the “substratum model” is that elaborated by Miksic.⁴⁶ While emphasizing the existence of an actual divide and antagonism between Hinduism and Buddhism in ancient Java, as documented by the alleged existence of unambiguously divided architectural and iconographical motifs and the occurrence of a “healthy competition” in order to gain royal support, Miksic passingly conceded that “adherents of both religions used the same substratum of artistic vocabulary to convey their philosophies”.⁴⁷

Hunter’s study on the Śiva-Buddha syncretism of Singhasari, while apparently conforming to the “agonistic model”, attempts at integrating socio-political aspects with theological ones. According to Hunter,

Kṛtanagara’s greatest achievement may be that in some sense he succeeded in making his own person the locus of unity between the two main streams of East Javanese religion, thereby affecting a religious union aimed at compelling the unseen forces of the cosmos to fall in behind his scheme of internal and external political unification.⁴⁸

Hence the fusion of Śaiva and Bauddha themes in Majapahit Java is to be attributed to the political and metaphysical agenda of Kṛtanagara, who pursued both goals of political hegemony and religious salvation.

A position that entirely conforms to the “borrowing model” is the one advanced by Soebadio⁴⁹ when analysing the inter-textual and doctrinal

relationships between Śaivism and Buddhism in Sanskrit-Old Javanese religious scriptures of the Tutar class. Substitution of Bauddha deities with Śaiva ones and vice versa is especially common in Tuturs of both religious orientations. Passages of the Śaiva *Jñānasiddhānta* run parallel with others found in the Bauddha *San Hyañ Kamahāyānikan* and the *Kalpabuddha*, but the latter texts substitute relevant terms used in the *Jñānasiddhānta* (e.g. the knowledge of non-duality personified into Vāgīśvarī or Praṇava Tridevī, chapter 3, pp. 80–83) into their Bauddha counterparts (e.g. Prajñāpāramitā). An analogous instance of “translation” of Śaiva ideas into Bauddha terms occurs in the *Sutasoma* Kakawin,⁵⁰ whose canto 41 contains speculations on the Bauddha *advayajñāna* or *advayayoga* and the Śaiva “way of dying” (*parātramārga*), both linked with the mantra *aṃ-aḥ*. The supreme goal, called *parambrahma* in the *Jñānasiddhānta*, is changed into *advayajñāna* in the *San Hyañ Kamahāyānikan* and the *Sutasoma*.

In his brief study on Javano-Balinese Śaivism, Sanderson⁵¹ has drawn the attention on the fact that in the Balinese ritual of *Sūrya Sevana*⁵² we find Prajñādevī and Parimitādevī as the last two of the eight goddesses of the eight fingers that are counted in the preliminary ritual of the cleansing of the hands. According to Sanderson, these two goddesses were evidently created out of the Bauddha Prajñāpāramitā. Therefore, referring to the ritual “contaminations” which have occurred in Bali, Cambodia and Kashmir, Sanderson expressed the view that “the needs and expectations of the clients have lead to thoroughly syncretistic developments in three independent cultural contexts”.⁵³ This attitude towards eclecticism is found in India as well, especially in the South Indian *paddhatis*, which were intended primarily as manuals whose aim is to guide the priest through the vast forest of Śaiva ritual.

REASSESSING THE SOURCES

On the basis of my reading of Old Javanese texts I have come to realize that any claim made in secondary literature that Śaivism and Buddhism were in Java and Bali syncretically united needs to be checked on the basis of a careful and impartial assessment of the extant textual evidence. Several important textual passages indeed appear to have been either incorrectly grasped or tendentiously (or perhaps subconsciously) misinterpreted, sometimes in order to attune them to modern political or religious agendas.⁵⁴

As noted by Miksic⁵⁵ and Santiko,⁵⁶ even in the Singhasari-Majapahit period Śaivism and Buddhism did not constitute a merger or synthesis of religious doctrine or praxis but maintained their independence as two

discrete systems, having separate types of religious structures for their respective priesthoods. My investigation into the corpus of premodern Old Javanese-cum-Sanskrit scriptures of Śaiva, and more rarely Bauddha, persuasion popularly known as Tuturs or Tattvas⁵⁷ has confirmed this view. In what may be identified as the earliest scriptures belonging to that corpus,⁵⁸ which stand closer, with respect to doctrine, to Sanskrit prototypical sources from South Asia, I have found no claim of equality between Śaiva and Bauddha elements. In fact no trace whatsoever of Buddhism as a system or of elements directly traceable to Buddhism is found in those sources. It is only in later sources, in all likelihood compiled during the Singhasari and Majapahit period (c.thirteenth–sixteenth century CE), or even later on Bali, that Tuturs invariably acknowledge the existence of three different “sects” called *tripakṣa*, namely Śaivas, Ṛṣis and Bauddhas or Saugatas, and to refer to the “Lord Śiva-Buddha”.

This state of affairs is mirrored in Kakawins written by Bauddha authors in East Java from the thirteenth to the fifteenth century, as well as in contemporary related pseudo-historical works, such as the *Deśawarṇana*, *Raṅga Lawe*, *Pararaton* and *Kidun Sunda*. These sources are also ready to acknowledge the equality of the Bauddha and Śaiva ultimate goals — yet not their soteric, yogic or ritual paths, which are clearly kept distinct. Correspondences between certain series of popular deities belonging to both traditions are also common. For instance, the Kakawin *Arjunawijaya*⁵⁹ of Mpu Tantular (stanzas 26.4–31.1), while maintaining that there is no distinction between Buddha and Śiva, states that they are distinct chosen objects of worship (*iṣṭidharma*) of the respective sects of the *tripakṣa*. It may thus be inferred that these religious streams maintained their integrity and peculiarity in the doctrinal, ritual and priestly domain, and therefore this unification is to be taken only in the ultimate sense. Similarly, *Sutasoma* 42.2 describes the yoga path of the Bauddhas and Śaivas not only as distinct, being respectively *advayajñāna* and *śaḍaṅgayoga*, but also leading to different goals; what it is claimed is that the followers of either path, in order to be successful, should know about the other as well. Mpu Tantular in stanzas 40.6 and 41.5 claims that the Bauddha path is more advanced and effective than the Śaiva one, which could become a pitfall to the true seeker of the ultimate Buddhist liberation insofar as it bestows supernatural powers that may lead the yogin astray. Furthermore, as already noted by Aoyama,⁶⁰ a marked critical attitude is evidently lying behind the whole *Sutasoma*, conceived as a Bauddha denunciation of the aberrant practices of certain Śaiva currents, embodied by the figure of the man-eater demon Poruṣāda. The pacification and “conversion” of protégées

of Śiva by prince Sutasoma thus reveals a Bauddha attempt to “convert” Śaiva followers to Buddhism.

With respect to the alleged syncretistic stance of the poem, we may here reiterate the point already made by Santoso, namely that

it is clear that the view that Śiva (or any other Hindu deity) may be regarded as Buddha is not held by the adherents of Hinduism. And in so far as Kern has claimed that Śiva is identified with Buddha, it can only be said that at times Śiva, like Brahmā, has appeared as a Bodhisattva. It is self-evident then, that had there been any attempt to bring about a unification of the two deities (which we do not concede) the initiative would come from the Buddhist and not from the Hindu.⁶¹

As is persuasively argued by Sanderson,⁶² the famous passage of the *Sutasoma* equating the realities (*dhātu*) of the Buddha (*jinatva*) and Śiva (*śivatattva*) (139.5) actually says that “the Lord Buddha is both the Buddha and Śiva” rather than espousing “a doctrine of absolute equality between the two religions within a reality beyond both”. Thus, to say that the two realities are but two manifestations of the ultimate reality of Buddha amounts to a thoroughly Bauddha perspective, similar to that exposed by Mpu Dusun in the *Kuñjarakarṇa* when stating that “I, Vairocana, am embodied both as the Buddha and as Śiva” (23.4bcd).⁶³ Several other passages of the *Sutasoma* that have been seen as evidence of either syncretism or coalition, namely 40.1–42.5 and 138.1–7 — to which we may add verses 22.1–23.4 of the *Kuñjarakarṇa*⁶⁴ — rather represent attempts from the Bauddhas to appropriate elements of the Śaivas and accommodate them within their own system, perhaps in order to draw support from the followers of the latter tradition. Similar considerations may apply to the Bauddha appropriation of elements of Śaiva iconography.

Now, this kind of attitude conforms quite well to Paul Hacker’s famous definition of “inclusivism” (*inklusivismus*):

Inclusivism is a concept I use to describe data from the area which we term Indian religion and, in particular, Indian religious philosophy. Inclusivism means declaring that a central conception of an alien religious or weltanschaulich group is identical with this or that central conception of the group to which one belongs oneself. To inclusivism there mostly belongs, explicitly or implicitly, the assertion that the alien declared to be identical with one’s own is in some way subordinate or inferior to the latter. In addition, no proof is generally furnished for the identity of the alien with one’s own.⁶⁵

Thus, even though inclusivism admits that alien religious systems may contain some truth it also regards the home religion as superior in that it teaches (more effectively) a higher level, or greater number, of religious truths. This viewpoint may be compared to the hierarchical distinction between levels of truth that amounts to the emic distinction between *lokottara* and *laukika*. However, from several statements of the *Sutasoma*, such as the famous statement *bhinneka tunggal ika* (“they are different; they are one”) of canto 139.5d, it is actually possible to understand the author’s standpoint to stand closer to Griffiths’⁶⁶ definition of “pluralism”, according to which (coexisting) separate but equal systems are all effective in bringing salvation about. This is different from the inclusivist perspective, which tends to favour one primary system while absorbing into it certain elements belonging to an alien tradition. Be this as it may, all claims of equivalence of realities made by Old Javanese Bauddha sources must be reconsidered in the light of the fact that for both inclusivistic and pluralistic thought equality does not imply identity. The same holds true with respect to Hunter’s claim that

the shift in emphasis within *kakawin* towards a “principle of equivalence” among the “three major sects” [...] must be linked to the career of Kṛtanagara, and his attempt to ensure political unity (and hegemony) through a symbolic amalgamation of the major religious currents of his time.⁶⁷

On the basis of the available evidence, it is perhaps too early to claim that “amalgamation” (which reminds us of Kern’s *vermenging*) is inherent to the “principle of equivalence”, which could otherwise be interpreted as a manifestation of the zealous activity of Bauddha authors and their courtly sponsors seeking to justify the appropriation of Śaiva elements into their pantheons. Even though we may concede that Kṛtanagara’s policy implied a genuine attempt on his side to syncretistically merge the two religions, we must remember that “there was never a figure prior to Kṛtanagara, nor one following him, who is described again and again in the inscriptional and literary records as *Bhatara Siwa-Buddha*”.⁶⁸ This fact suggests that his peculiar view was not endorsed by the majority of the contemporary religious clergies.⁶⁹

It may also be pointed out, as noted by Sferra with respect to South Asian Sanskrit texts,⁷⁰ that claims of equivalence between Śaiva and Bauddha supreme realities are a prominent feature of non-dualist Tantric literature. It may thus be argued that monism makes it easier to justify every aspect of existence as relative manifestations of one and the same

absolute. It is entirely plausible that Kṛtanagara's milieu, as suggested by the textual references and iconographical elements that are traceable to it,⁷¹ partook of the non-dualist and antinomian currents centred on the cult of Kāla-Bhairava, a deity that in the Subcontinent is worshiped in both Śaiva and Bauddha circles.

Features that are comparable to those attested in non-dualist Tantric sources are also detectable in certain Old Javanese and Old Sundanese Tuturs which, judging from their colophons and palaeographic features, were in all probability composed in the late Majapahit period (sixteenth century) in circumscribed mountainous enclaves where Kabuyutans (i.e. "scriptoria") were located.⁷² Showing a marked predilection for mystical, moralistic and didactic purposes, these texts⁷³ are the expression of a kind of "popular" religiosity characterized by an embedded approach to religious experience, where Śaiva and Bauddha elements are reconfigured along markedly "localized" lines, and where the divide between the two religious schools seems to have become less important and virtually imperceptible. Although the paucity of historical information on the social contexts in which these texts were composed and used does not allow us to draw any firm conclusion, it may be argued that this type of syncretistic approach to religious experience was confined to certain isolated milieus rather than constituting the mainstream.

Shifting our attention to Bali, it may be noted, if only fleetingly, that several Tuturs among those composed in the period following the fall of Majapahit in the sixteenth century share similar characteristics with Tuturs stemming from the Sundanese enclaves described above. These texts, composed in Old Javanese but featuring many Balinisms, bear witness to a status quo where Śaiva and Bauddha elements lose their distinct character and coalesce into a mystical synthesis — witness the frequent references to Bhaṭāra Śiva-Buddha, and claims that the doctrines and yogic techniques they describe are the preserve of the Brahmans of the *tripakṣa* indistinctively.⁷⁴ It is to this unwieldy and virtually unstudied corpus of texts that modern *Agama Hindu Bali* owes, in many respects, its textual foundation.

Yet, in spite of the apparent lack of divide between Śaivas and Bauddhas propounded by these predominantly mystical Balinese sources, one hardly notes a syncretistic amalgamation between the two streams. Rather, the relationship between Buddhism and Śaivism on Bali since the Majapahit period seems to have assumed the contours of a symbiosis or Śaiva-Bauddha coalition — not so much in the domain of doctrine as in that of ritual. As the inferior status of the Pedanda Buddha and its

subsidiary — albeit indispensable — role in ritual with respect to Pedanda Śiva suggests, Buddhism has traditionally been regarded by the Balinese as inferior to Śivaism. As testified to by the illuminating remarks of such a reliable observer as Crawfurd, there is no doubt that on Bali, even as late as the early nineteenth century, Śivaism was predominant over Buddhism:

It is of the Hinduism of the sect of Śiva only, that I can furnish any detailed information. The Buddhists are few in number. [...] The followers of Siva spoke of these of Buddha more with contempt than hatred or rancor — the last, indeed, are feelings not likely to be entertained by any people for a fallen sect; in which light the Buddhists were evidently looked upon. The Brahmans in their conversation often let fall expressions, which showed that they entertained no respect whatever for the followers of the opposite worship. The sect of Siva may indeed be denominated the national religion. It is the religion of nine-tenths of the people, of every sovereign on the island, and of every man in power.⁷⁵

Crawfurd’s statement suggests that there existed a clear divide between the two religions, and that the Balinese status quo may be comparable to the *laukika/lokottara* contrastive distinction. The situation that developed on the island might be regarded as the result of a dialectic relationship thanks to which the two religions have finally come to terms — one (Śivaism) recognizing the (partial and relative) validity and inferior status of the other.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

Having surveyed the previous literature touching upon the relationship of Śivaism and Buddhism in Java and Bali, as well as in the Indian Subcontinent, I have critically assessed the view that a syncretistic, and unitary, Śiva-Buddha religion characterized the mainstream religiosity of the Singhasari-Majapahit period. Having found the three main hermeneutical models employed by scholars of Śivaism and Buddhism in the Subcontinent to be applicable also to the analysis of the dialectic between the two religions in the Archipelago, I have argued that the equivalence of Śaiva and Bauddha supreme goals and/or deities claimed by certain Old Javanese sources may be regarded as attempts by one system (mostly Buddhism) to appropriate familiar elements of the other. This phenomenon of appropriation would appear to have been driven by an “inclusivist” or, at times, “pluralist” attitude. Going against past claims regarding such a phenomenon as a typically or uniquely local feature that

would reflect a supposed “openness” and eclecticism of the people of the Indonesian Archipelago with regard to religious matters, I stressed the need to analyse it against a local, context-specific background on the one hand, and a larger, pan-Asian context of exchange and dialectic between the two religions on the other.

My argument is that in investigating such complex and multifarious phenomenon as the relationship between Śivaism and Buddhism in premodern Indonesia, one cannot follow an approach that is narrowly theoretical (e.g. “structuralist”, like Rassers’) without running the risk of producing an ahistorical picture. Since this relationship entailed variation according to genres and media of expression, milieu of production and geographical location; underwent considerable development over time; and was context-specific, it follows that a historicist and multidisciplinary approach must be adopted — accompanied by a more careful and philologically sound assessment of original textual sources.

Let me conclude by trying to answer, if only in a very preliminary manner, the question as to what would have triggered Bauddha appropriations of Śaiva elements. Being persuaded by the arguments elaborated by Hunter, which conform to a “secular and historicist interpretation”, I am of the opinion that Kṛtanagara’s religio-ritual agenda, dominated by antinomian practices associated with Kāla-Bhairava, exerted a significant impact on the formation of a coalition between Śivaism and Buddhism, and between the respective religious clergies — their unease notwithstanding. Kṛtanagara’s endeavour would have served the purpose of forming an analogous, and all-powerful, coalition against his external (as well as internal) political enemies in the real world.

Yet, this historical fact alone is not sufficient to fully explain the *status quo* depicted by the (Old Javanese, Middle Javanese and Old Sundanese) written sources. Phenomena of appropriation that reflect what I have deemed to be an “inclusivist” or “pluralist” attitude cannot be uniquely the result of historical-political circumstances but are likely to have been shaped by different cultural dynamics. For example, we may locate these in a Javanese (as well as Balinese) context where Śivaism has been for several centuries the dominant religion and Buddhism, albeit widespread on the territory, represented a minority. In such milieus, where Old Javanese belles-lettres had traditionally been the prerogative of Śaiva poets sponsored by Śaiva Kings, the efflorescence of literary specimens of Bauddha inspiration claiming the identity of Bauddha and Śaiva elements would constitute attempts by pious authors at proselytizing among their readership and, at the same time, gain royal support. The inclusion and appropriation of

Śaiva elements by the Bauddhas through operations of textual bricolage so paradigmatically exemplified by the *San̄ Hyaṇ̄ Kamahāyānikan*, one recension of which embeds an originally Śaiva treatise on yoga,⁷⁶ would constitute attempts at marketing the former system’s religious truths in a more effective way, following an approach that is in every respect analogous to the one documented by Sanderson with respect to South Asian Sanskrit sources.

On the other hand, the pronounced Śaiva and Bauddha coalitions — if not actual “syncretisms” — of soteric means and doctrinal items documented in Tuturs stemming from late-Majapahit popular milieus may be regarded as hybrid cultural expressions of peripheral cosmopolitan areas, where original sectarian boundaries ceased to play a relevant role in framing the everyday religious experience. What caused a progressive hybridization of Śivaism and Buddhism, as well as their convergence towards a higher “mystic synthesis” — much like the one that eventually developed in Javanese milieus after the contact with Islam since the fifteenth century — might have been the progressive departure from the point of origin, and zenith, of the Indic religious and cultural values carried by the Sanskrit Cosmopolis; their ensuing transformation and “localization”; and the decadence of traditional forms of clergy, along with the development of new cultic embedded orthopraxies.

Notes

1. According to the Chinese pilgrim Fa-Hsien, on Java (Ye-Po-Ti) around 414 CE the followers of Buddhism were much fewer than the “Brahmans and infidels”. A few years later, other Chinese sources speak of a widespread diffusion of Buddhism over the island (cf. Ensink, “Śiva-Buddhism in Java and Bali”, pp. 178–79). Yi-Jing visited Sumatra in 689–692 CE, noting a significant Buddhist presence. Although many contemporary expressions of “Balinese Buddhism” may be the result of modern revivalism, it should be noted that enclaves of “Bauddha Brahmanas” are extant on Bali, especially in the eastern region of Karangasem; it is these communities that have preserved the rare Old Javanese texts of Bauddha persuasion (cf. Hooykaas, *Balinese Bauddha Brahmanas*).
2. See, for instance, Snellgrove’s article eloquently titled “Syncretism as a main feature of Indonesian culture”.
3. Kern, “Over de vermenging van Çiwaisme en Buddhisme op Java”.
4. Krom, *Inleiding tot de Hindoe-Javaansche Kunst*.
5. Rassers, *Pañji, the culture hero*; “Śiva en Boeddha in den Indischen Archipel”.
6. The two brothers Bubhukṣa and Gagaṇ Akiṇ have been regarded to represent, respectively, the Śaiva and Bauddha ascetic way (cf. Ensink, “Sutasoma’s

- Teaching to Gajavaktra,” pp. 201–201; “Śīva-Buddhism in Java and Bali”, pp. 186–87). Gagañ Akiñ is the quintessentially Śaīva ascetic, practising severe austerities and dietary restrictions, while his brother enjoys eating all sorts of food including meat and indulges in drinking alcohol. After having been put to trial by God who had descended on earth in the form of a tigress, both obtain liberation and ascend to heaven, although Bubhukṣa’s method is perceived as superior to the one of his older brother.
7. Krom, *Inleiding tot de Hindoe-Javaansche Kunst*, pp. 118–19.
 8. Rassers, *Pañji, the culture hero*, pp. 65–66.
 9. Zoetmuder, “Die Hochreligionen Indonesiens”, pp. 301–304.
 10. Pigeaud, *Java in the Fourteenth Century*, pp. 3–4.
 11. Gonda, “Śīva in Indonesien”, p. 28.
 12. *Ibid.*, pp. 27–30.
 13. Soebadio, *Jñānasiddhānta*, pp. 55ff.
 14. Supomo, “‘Lord of the Mountains’ in the Fourteenth Century *kakawin*”.
 15. de Casparis and I.W. Mabbett, “Religion and Popular Beliefs of Southeast Asia before c. 1500”, pp. 328–29.
 16. Santoso, *Sutasoma*.
 17. Ensink, “Śīva-Buddhism in Java and Bali”, pp. 192–93.
 18. Nihom, *Studies in Indian and Indo-Indonesian Tantrism*.
 19. Hunter, “The Body of the King”.
 20. *Ibid.*, p. 52.
 21. The earliest scriptures belonging to this corpus might have already been in existence by the fifth century CE, however it is only from the seventh century that evidence for the circulation of fully-fledged Tantric texts begins to appear in South Asia. The upper limit for most of the revealed scriptures (Tantras, Āgamas, Sūtras) of both Śaīva and Bauddha persuasion may be drawn to the c. tenth–eleventh century CE.
 22. Seyfort Rugg, “Sur les rapports entre le bouddhisme et le ‘substrat religieux’ indien et tibétain”; “A note on the Relationship between Buddhist and ‘Hindu’ Divinities in Buddhist Literature and Iconology”; *The symbiosis of Buddhism with Brahmanism/Hinduism in South Asia and of Buddhism with ‘local cults’ in Tibet and the Himalayan region*.
 23. Seyfort Rugg, *The symbiosis of Buddhism ...*, p. vi.
 24. *Ibid.*, pp. 11 and 134, notes that the opposition between *laukika* and *lokottara* recalls the distinction between the etic categories of “Little Tradition” and “Great Tradition”.
 25. Sanderson, “Vajrayāna: Origin and Function”.
 26. See Sanderson, “Vajrayāna: Origin and Function”; “History through Textual Criticism in the Study of Śaivism, the Pañcarātra and the Buddhist Yoginītantras”, “Śaivism among the Khmers”, “The Śaīva Age”; Bühnemann, “Buddhist Deities and Mantras in the Hindu Tantras I”, p. 303; and Seyfort Rugg, “A note on the Relationship between Buddhist and ‘Hindu’ Divinities in Buddhist Literature and Iconology”, p. 737.

27. Sanderson, “Śaivism among the Khmers”, pp. 436, 440.
28. Seyfort Rugg, *The symbiosis of Buddhism ...*, p. viii.
29. Ibid., p. 109.
30. Sferra, “Some Considerations on the Relationship Between Hindu and Buddhist Tantras”.
31. Ibid., p. 61.
32. Coedès, *Les états hindouisés d’Indochine et d’Indonésie*, pp. 90, 107.
33. Krom, *Hindoe-Javaansche geschiedenis*, pp. 172–73.
34. de Casparis, *Prasasti Indonesia II*, p. 300.
35. Damais, “Bibliographie Indonésienne”.
36. Jordaan, *In praise of Prambanan*; “Co-existence of religions in ancient Central Java”.
37. Ibid., pp. 122–23.
38. Bosch, *Het vraagstuk van de Hindoe-kolonisatie van den archipel*.
39. Sarkar, “The evolution of the Siva-Buddha cult in Java”.
40. Bosch, *Het vraagstuk van de Hindoe-kolonisatie van den archipel*, quoted in Jordaan, “Co-existence of religions in ancient Central Java”, pp. 124–25.
41. Jordaan and Wessing, “Human sacrifice of Prambanan”, p. 65.
42. Nihom, *Studies in Indian and Indo-Indonesian Tantrism*, p. 15.
43. Teeuw and Robson, *Kuṅṅjara-karṇa Dharmakathana*, p. 9.
44. Nihom, *Studies in Indian and Indo-Indonesian Tantrism*, pp. 20–21.
45. Ibid., p. 114.
46. Miksic, “The Buddhist-Hindu Divide in Premodern Southeast Asia”.
47. Ibid., p. 5.
48. Hunter, “The Body of the King”, p. 41.
49. Soebadio, *Jñānasiddhānta*, pp. 12–15.
50. Santoso, *Sutasoma*.
51. Sanderson, “Śaivism among the Khmers”, p. 377.
52. See Hooykaas, *Sūryasevana*, p. 50.
53. Sanderson, “Śaivism among the Khmers”, p. 377.
54. This holds especially true in the case of certain secondary literature in Indonesian, either of scholarly or popular nature that, in the light of the dictum *bhinneka tunggal ika* (“unity in diversity”) of the *Sutasoma* that has become the official motto of the Indonesian Republic, likes to see in the religious eclecticism of the Majapahit period the origin of the principle of religious pluralism laying at the basis of the modern Indonesian state, or a manifestation of the “openness” and accommodating attitude of many Indonesians with respect to religious matters.
55. Miksic, “The Buddhist-Hindu Divide in Premodern Southeast Asia”, pp. 5–6.
56. Santiko, “Early Research on Sivaitic Hinduism during the Majapahit Era”, p. 62.
57. These texts, preserved by the hundreds on Balinese palm-leaf manuscripts, and on just a handful of rare palm-leaf manuscripts from Java, form the textual basis of Śaivism in the Indonesian Archipelago. A salient feature

- of the Tuttur/Tattva literature is the translation and reconfiguration of Indic elements pertaining to linguistic, soteriological and theological domains into a local context of doctrine and practice. A survey of this corpus of texts may be found in Acri, “The Sanskrit-Old Javanese Tuttur Literature from Bali”.
58. Namely the *Vṛhaspatitattva*, *Tattvajñāna*, *Mahājñāna*, *Tuttur Kamokṣan*, *Bhuvanakośa*, *Bhuvanasaṅkṣepa* and *Dharma Pātāñjala*. Although some of these scriptures are compilations of materials of different provenance, they are likely to have reached their definitive forms already by the tenth or eleventh century CE.
 59. Supomo, *Arjunawijaya*.
 60. Aoyama, “Prince and Priest”, pp. 10ff.
 61. Santoso, *Sutasoma*, p. 42.
 62. Sanderson, “The Śaiva Age”, fn. 287, pp. 124–25.
 63. Ibid., p. 124.
 64. See Teeuw and Robson, *Kuñjarakarna Dharmakathana*, pp. 122–25.
 65. Quoted and translated from the German by Seyfort Ruegg, *The symbiosis of Buddhism...*, p. 97.
 66. Griffiths, *Problems of Religious Diversity*, p. 15.
 67. Hunter, “The Body of the King”, p. 38.
 68. Ibid., p. 34.
 69. Ibid., p. 41, refers to a passage of the *Deśavarṇana* (56.2–57.4) mentioning the disappearance of the image of Akṣobhya from Caṇḍi Jawi, which might have been due to the intervention of the Śaiva abbot out of his negative judgment of Kṛtanagara’s syncretistic attitude, and which was taken by Prapañca as the cause of the sanctuary being struck by lightning in 1331 CE.
 70. Sferra, “Some Considerations on the Relationship Between Hindu and Buddhist Tantras”, pp. 68–69, has noted that texts belonging to Bauddha and Śaiva non-dualist traditions tend to show no fundamental difference between the descriptions of the paramount goals of their respective soteriological paths, for instance emptiness (*śūnyatā*) or oneness with Śiva (*śivātmaka*).
 71. Witness, for instance, the Sukāmṛta inscription of 1259 CE, which suggests the existence of a link between Kṛtanagara’s East Javanese milieu and Bhairavika Śivaism (cf. Santiko, “Early Research on Sivaitic Hinduism during the Majapahit Era”, p. 58; Hunter, “The Body of the King”, pp. 35–36); and the King’s allegiance, as suggested by canto 43 of the *Deśavarṇana*, to Tantric Bauddha rituals connected with the Kālacakra system and such texts as the *Guhyasamājantra* and *Hevajratantra* — seemingly in response to the consecration of his rival, the Mongol emperor Kublai Khan, into an analogous ritual path (cf. Hunter, “The Body of the King”, pp. 35–36; Moens, “Het Boeddhisme op Java en Sumatra in zijn laatste bloeiperiode”, especially pp. 527–30).
 72. That such Kabuyutans represented what had survived of the hermitages (*patapan*) of the Śaiva ascetics of the Ṛṣi group is suggested by Old Sundanese

- accounts such as the Bhujanga Manik (cf. Noorduyn, “Bujangga Manik’s journeys through Java”, pp. 416–18; Aciri, *Dharma Pāṭaṅjala*, pp. 44–48; Noorduyn and Teeuw, *Three Old Sundanese Poems*, p. 281). Note further that in the Ciburuy scriptorium, along with a collection of palm-leaf manuscripts, may be found a few Śaiva and Bauddha implements, namely a trident and a vajra-bell (I have witnessed this myself on occasion of my visits there).
73. Including the *San Hyan Siksa Kandaṅ Karṣian* (Old Sundanese), *San Hyan Hayu* (Old Javanese) and the many versions thereof, *Siksa Guru* (Old Javanese), *Bhimasorga* (Old Javanese-cum-Old Sundanese), etc. A survey of these texts, a handful of which have been translated into Indonesian, may be found in Noorduyn and Teeuw, *Three Old Sundanese Poems*, pp. 2–6; cf. also *Dharma Pāṭaṅjala*, pp. 3–8.
 74. See *Gaṇapatitattva* (ed. Sudarshana Devi), Old Javanese prose appendix to *ślokas* 51–53 paragraph 13, referring to the *saṅ brāhmaṇa bhujāṅga* (i.e. Ṛṣis) *śaiva sogata* (i.e. Bauddhas); *Jñānasiddhānta* chapter 5 (pp. 86–87, 106–107), mentioning *śaiva* and *bauddha*, both qualified by the expression *saṅ bhujāṅga* — which would thus appear to have lost its usual connotation of “member of the Ṛṣi group” to indicate a Brahman or person of religious rank.
 75. Crawford, “On the Existence of the Hindu Religion in the Island of Bali”, pp. 129–30.
 76. See Lokesh Chandra, “Śaiva Version of Saṅ Hyan Kamahāyānikan”, p. 7.

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